



Unearthed Arcana

Achievements

By Robert J. Schwalb

Illustrations by Tyler Jacobson, Ryan Pancoast, Wayne England, Chris Seaman, and Ania Mohrbacher

After the expedition to the Thunderspire Labyrinth, everyone agreed they needed a break. On returning to Fallcrest, the Company of Swords broke apart. They each split off to spend their treasure, pursue their private interests, and find some quiet time. They all believed a few peaceful weeks would do them good.

On the appointed night when they were to regroup, Corgan shifted in his seat. He peered into his empty tankard with a skeptical eye, searching for another drop. It wouldn't do to get drunk, not before heading off to that queer pyramid.

Most of his companions sat with him, sharing their stories of romance and investment, business and secrets uncovered. Corgan ignored them all. His eye was on the door. One member was missing, and they couldn't leave this town until all were accounted for. Syl was late as usual, probably because he was still talking his way out of jail.

Just as Corgan was about to head off to the watch headquarters to bail out the thief, the slight halfling slipped through the doors. His eyes shifted back and forth. He glided between the tables, watching the other patrons. When he looked up and spied Corgan, he grinned and mopped his brow with a red cloth.

"Corgan, my friend! Sorry I'm late. You'll never guess what happened to me. Remember that cult we've been tracking? Well..."

Throughout an adventurer's career, gold, magic items, jewels, and other treasures find their way into his or her pockets. Such wonders provide impetus for

venturing into the world's most dangerous places. Although nobler reasons might propel the heroes into dungeons and ruins, plunder compensates the hero for risks taken and injuries sustained. But are there rewards beyond the coins and enchanted trinkets?

Of course there are. Intangible rewards, described in the *Rules Compendium*[™], include such things as medals, titles, and favors. These minor gains result from completing quests; they have little to no monetary value. Instead, they add color to your character, advance the story, or perhaps add a circumstantial benefit to situations in which their possession proves advantageous. For example, a medal might give the character access to the duke's court, while calling in a favor might allow the character to reach a portal to a far-flung destination.

In addition to these minor rewards, there are achievements. Similarly, these don't usually have a monetary value—or at least a value that fits into the game's economy. An achievement is often quite a bit larger and more important to the story, and its acquisition can shape the campaign in different ways. Although achievements might be similar to other intangible rewards such as castles, ships, lands, titles, and so on, they differ in how one achieves them. Rather than gaining the information or boon through game play, players gain achievements between adventures, when their characters pursue their interests. In effect, achievements are rewards gained during downtime—even between gaming sessions.

USING ACHIEVEMENTS

Achievements enrich campaigns. Their acquisition adds definition to adventurers, grounding them in the world and helping them shape their environment in meaningful ways. Furthermore, achievements let players take an active role in advancing the plot by following up on leads and developing those hooks that draw them into the next adventure.

Achievement Categories

Each achievement falls into one of the following categories.

Association: Association achievements are ones where you make a connection to a nonplayer character (NPC) or organization. You might join a thieves' guild, enlist in an army, woo a potential lover, or befriend a powerful person. These achievements lay foundations for other achievements. For instance, after seducing a noble, you might later try to convince her to help you (influence), share gossip (information), or fund a nautical expedition (material).

Influence: Attaining an influence achievement lets you alter the story in some way. These achievements change your circumstances or the circumstances of another. Examples include getting invited to the duke's ball, convincing a constable to release a prisoner, gaining access to a guarded library, or convincing a ship captain to delay departure. Influence achievements often set up future adventures.

Information: Tracking down a villain to his or her hideout, deciphering a coded message, or mapping a region are all information achievements. In effect, you learn an important clue or fact. This information might reveal why something happened, what something means, or where you might go next.

Material: Material achievements give you ownership of something. Normally, these achievements do not modify your character's abilities; they are simply objects such as castles and ships. They have story

consequences rather than mechanical ones. Further, such items do not always require an investment of treasure. In some cases, the achievement does, in fact, give you an object you can use in your adventures, like a magic item. In this case, however, you must pay its price to gain the achievement.

Gaining Achievements

Achievements are like any other reward and can be gained through normal adventuring. You might clear a castle of its inhabitants and claim it as part of your spoils. Or saving the crown princess might reward you with influence in the king's court, titles to lands, or guarded information about the king's ancestry. Achievements differ from other rewards, however, in that you can gain them between adventures, during the downtime after a successful expedition. Narrative challenges provide a way to gain achievements when you're not otherwise engaged in the campaign's story.

Narrative Challenges

Narrative challenges resemble skill challenges in many ways. During a narrative challenge, you name an objective. You then make a series of skill checks and, based on your successes and failures, achieve or don't achieve your objective. There are differences, however.

A narrative challenge almost never takes place during an actual adventure. Instead, you play through the challenge during downtime, when your character might otherwise be resting, investing treasure, or waiting for the next adventure to begin. The narrative challenge describes how your character spends his or her time and what gains that character earns for his or her efforts.

Because narrative challenges most often occur between game sessions and can be played with or without a Dungeon Master, they have more structure than a skill challenge. Each narrative challenge has a tight script featuring several skill checks with built-in

results. Your successes and failures propel your character through the challenge to the conclusion, wherein you learn whether you gained the achievement.

Finally, a narrative challenge is usually a solitary enterprise. It's possible for two or more characters to participate in the same narrative challenge, with allies aiding a lead character. If the entire party becomes involved, however, the Dungeon Master might instead construct an adventure or skill challenge to replace the narrative challenge.

The Basics

Every narrative challenge unfolds in a similar manner. First, you choose a desired achievement: make an association, influence the story, gain information, or acquire material goods. Next, you move through the stages of the challenge. At each stage, you make a skill check. The check result determines the next stage and the next skill check. After several stages, you reach the end of the challenge and learn the consequences.

Components of a Narrative Challenge

Narrative challenges have five main components.

1. Achievement: The achievement of a challenge is your objective, which you hope to gain by reaching the challenge's conclusion.

2. Time: A narrative challenge takes more time than does a typical skill challenge. A narrative challenge can take days, weeks, or even months to complete.

3. Level and DCs: Many narrative challenges are open to characters of any level and will have a level equal to that of the character undertaking it. A few might require a minimum level; they will include this requirement in the challenge's description.

When the challenge calls for a skill check, it describes the DC as being easy, moderate, or hard. Find the Difficulty Class by Level table in the *Rules Compendium*. Your level determines the DC for these checks. For example, if your character is 5th level and

the challenge calls for a hard Athletics check, you would make the check against a DC 22.

4. Skill Stages: Each challenge includes several stages. Within a stage is a description of what it entails, the skill needed to move through the stage, and the consequences for success or failure, usually resulting in you moving to a different stage. Depending on your check result, you might gain a bonus or penalty to your next skill check. Bonuses and penalties are cumulative.

Some stages include a shortcut. A shortcut provides an alternative path through the stage, usually because of a power, ritual, or item. Shortcuts might also include skill checks.

5. Conclusion: The conclusion describes how the challenge ends. The outcome depends on whether you reached this stage with a success or a failure. Usually, a success means you gain the desired achievement while failure means you don't. In addition, a failure might have other negative and story-related consequences. These might create complications, encourage a hasty escape from town, or spark another adventure.

A narrative challenge grants no XP reward. The achievement itself is the reward.

Using Narrative Challenges

Narrative challenges are a powerful tool to explore what happens when the characters aren't involved in an adventure. They are not always appropriate or needed, however; before running a narrative challenge, keep the following in mind.

Work with the DM: Explain to the DM what achievement you hope to gain, why it's important to your character, and how it can advance the story. You might want to track a villain to his or her lair, only to learn the DM plans to make this a feature of the next adventure. Also, the DM might have story reasons for putting off your request. Building your castle might

be fine, but if your party is heading off to a different continent, you won't be able to enjoy the castle.

Downtime: The most common way to use narrative challenges is during downtime between adventures, but they can also be used between game sessions. Perhaps the characters are on an adventure in a city, and they have separate tasks that will further the story (learning where the thieves' guild has its hideout, bribing an official for the authority to fight the thieves, researching a strange magical tattoo all the thieves have, and so on). You can play out the result of the characters' efforts between sessions and thus come to the table ready to keep the adventure going.

Side Trek: A character might split from the party to pursue a different lead or to do something related to the adventure. A narrative challenge can provide a quick resolution to this subplot so you can get back to the game's central focus.

Fit the Story: A narrative challenge should fit into the larger story. Before a character can work toward a particular achievement, think about where the character is, how much time he or she has, and whether the desired achievement is even possible. For example, a character spending a week in the Nine Hells' Iron City of Dis probably won't be able to build a castle both because of location and time. Likewise, it's probably not possible to woo Esmeralda in Fallcrest when the characters are spending three days in Winterhaven.

Managing the Challenge: You can play through a narrative challenge by yourself, but your DM might want to be present to help structure the results. You might handle this during a break in the game, before or after the session, or even by exchanging emails. Most challenges don't take more than a few minutes to resolve, so you can get the results quickly.

Example of Play

This example shows a player and a DM working together before a game session to run through a narrative challenge. The adventurer is Rook (a drow thief). After defeating the Stormcrows in Forlorn Tower, the adventuring party returned to Wellspring for some much-needed downtime. Rook, however, decides to use the downtime to spy on an NPC named Dierdra. A priestess of Ioun, she has been a sometime-ally, but she could not explain her presence in Wellspring when she was supposed to be leading refugees south to Sumberton. Rook's player explains to the DM what he'd like to do. The DM agrees there's time and offers to run through the narrative challenge.

Rook is 12th level, so his DCs are 14 for easy, 20 for moderate, and 28 for hard. The DM picks the "Track Down a Villain" challenge and modifies the stages to fit the story. The achievement is to learn if Dierdra is engaged in any suspicious activity. If Rook succeeds, he gains an information achievement: knowledge that Dierdra is up to no good. If Rook fails, he doesn't find out any useful information.

DM: So you think Dierdra is up to something, huh?

Rook: I'm sure of it, and I aim to prove it.

DM: What do you want to do?

Rook: Seems to me the best place to start is to figure out where she is now. If I can corner her, I plan to ask some very pointed questions.

DM: Right. To learn this information, you'll need to make a Streetwise check. And, just so you know, this will take an hour.

Rook: Understood. I got a 21.

DM: Great! Well, you prowl Wellspring's back alleys, and you drift into a few taverns to talk to folk from the streets. A toothless fellow, smelling of sour milk, tells you he saw her at the Red Feather Inn. He was collecting his crust of bread from the kind matron

there when he saw a woman matching Dierdra's description slip inside. That was an hour ago.

Rook: Huh. Does he know anything else? Namely, where this inn might be?

DM: That's all he knows, though he can point you to the inn. He mentions that he doesn't want any trouble for the matron. He'd hate to go hungry.

Rook: I leave him and head off to the Red Feather.

DM: All right. You find the inn where the toothless man said it would be, tucked into an alley off a side street. What do you want to do now?

Rook: I'll stake out the place. Is there anywhere I can hide?

DM: Sure, though it'll obstruct your view a bit.

Rook: The last thing I want to do at this point is show my hand. Yeah, I'll hide. I got a 28 on my Stealth check.

DM: Wow! You're invisible or darn close to it. You find a good place to hide and watch the inn. How long do you want to wait?

Rook: I'm a drow. I can go all night long.

DM: Right. Okay, then, make a Perception check.

Rook: Ugh, a 1. I got a 9 total.

DM: You were looking down at the time, but you think someone just left the inn. You can try again, but you'll need to come out from hiding.

Rook: Yeah. Fine. That's better. A 20.

DM: It was Dierdra. She didn't notice you. What now?

Rook: I'm going to shadow her.

DM: Right. Give me a Stealth check.

Rook: Good grief! Another 1. That's an 18.

DM: Uh-oh. You follow her steps, keeping pace and trying to stay out of her view. Something draws her attention—maybe a sound you made. She looks your way and meets your eyes. She snarls once and then starts running. In an instant, she's out of view.

Rook: I'll give chase.

DM: Okay, make an Athletics check.

Rook: Ugh, my dice hate me! I got a 14.

DM: No problem. It was enough. You keep up with her, following her through the city. A couple times she almost got away. Finally, you come to the town square. You know, the one with the big weird statue?

Rook: Right. The one pointing toward the mountains.

DM: That's the one. Well, she stops in front of it and does something to a rock. She gives you one last hate-filled glare and then slips inside the statue.

Rook: Darn it! Hmm. I want to check out that statue.

DM: Sure thing. How about a Perception check?

Rook: Already on it. This time a 21.

DM: Good job. Yep. You find a secret door. There's a latch hidden in the carving.

Rook: I want to keep going, but I don't think that would be a good idea without the rest of the party. I'm heading back to the inn to tell them what I found out.

Rook gained the information achievement at the end when he discovered Dierdra was up to something and also that there was a secret door in the statue. Had Rook pressed on, he would have moved out of the narrative challenge and into an encounter area. The DM would run this as a normal adventure, though a dangerous one since Rook would be going alone.

Because the DM was involved, she could adjust the narrative challenge to suit the situation. Had Rook run through this challenge alone, he would have just followed the options presented in the script.

SAMPLE NARRATIVE CHALLENGES

The following narrative challenges provide ready-to-use examples to gain specific achievements. You can use them as written or adjust them to fit your circumstances.

Blaze a Trail

You scout the wilderness to learn the lay of the land.

Since the last empire's fall, the wilderness has reclaimed lands once civilized. New growth covers the old trade routes, and the few surviving paths are perilous, haunted by cruel humanoids and vicious monsters. Even the waterways are unsafe. To reach a distant destination, one must endure not only travel's rigors but also the many perils lying in wait.

Achievement (Information): You explore a region to find a safe path to a destination about a week's travel away. If you succeed, you find or create a path to speed your travel.

Time: 1 week

Stage 1: The Expedition Begins

You leave civilization's bounds and venture into the unknown.

Exploring the wilderness is hard work. To survey the land quickly, you must push yourself and keep walking and keep searching even when fatigue sets in. Make an Endurance check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You are more than equal to the task. You gain a +2 bonus to Athletics checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 2.

Success: You hold up well. Go to stage 2.

Failure: You are fatigued. You take a -2 penalty to the skill check in the next stage. Go to stage 2.

Failure by 5 or more: You are exhausted, and you must rest. You take a -2 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. You must repeat this stage. If you get this result a second time, go to the conclusion.

Stage 2: Difficult Terrain

You come to a tough obstacle, such as a white-water river, a cliff, or a chasm.

To overcome the obstacle, you must climb, jump, or swim. Make an Athletics check against a moderate DC.



Success by 5 or more: You easily overcome the obstacle. You can roll twice for your next skill check and take the higher result. Go to stage 3.

Success: You overcome the obstacle and continue your journey. Go to stage 3.

Failure: You are banged up. Maybe you slipped and fell or the river carried you downstream. You take a -2 penalty to the skill check during the next stage. Go to stage 3.

Failure by 5 or more: You fail to get through the obstacle and are injured in the process. You must repeat this stage with a -2 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. If you gain this result a second time, go to the conclusion.

Stage 3: Find a Good Vantage

Having explored the region, you move off to get a good view.

You must find a location to gain a good overview of the terrain. Make a Nature check against an easy DC.

Success by 5 or more: You know just where to look. You gain a +2 bonus to Perception checks during the next stage. Go to stage 4.

Success: You find a serviceable lookout. Go to stage 4.

Failure: You find a lookout, though the view is poor. You take a -2 penalty to Perception checks during the next stage.

Failure by 5 or more: You can't find a suitable lookout. Go to the conclusion.

Stage 4: Study the Land

From your vantage, you inspect your surroundings to find a good path.

You study the landscape. Make a Perception check against a moderate DC.

Success: You find a perfect path. Go to the conclusion.

Failure: You don't find a viable path. Go to the conclusion.

Conclusion

After exploring the wilderness, you return to civilization.

If you reached the conclusion from a success, you create a workable map of the area. When traveling through this region, you and all allies with you treat any difficult terrain as one step better for determining your speed according to the Base Exploration Speed and Terrain and Travel tables in the *Rules Compendium*. Additionally, you gain a +2 bonus to all skill checks related to skill challenges needed to travel through this region.

If you reached the conclusion from a failure, you found little success and thus gain no benefits when you travel through this region.

Build a Stronghold

A lasting edifice to honor your achievements, a stronghold will stand long after you have gone.

From castles to fortified temples and from monasteries to primal lodges, a stronghold gives you a place to call home and serves as a retreat from the world's demands where you can rest, recover, and plan your next expedition. Building a stronghold is no easy endeavor. It requires funding, architects, labor, and materials.

Achievement (Material): You work to construct a stronghold. You decide the stronghold's form, purpose, appearance, and location. A stronghold does not normally exceed areas larger than 20 by 30 squares. You can break up the area as you like into rooms, floors, cellars, and so forth. To expand your stronghold, you need to run through this narrative challenge again.

Time: Six months to a year, depending on scope and materials.

Stage 1: Gain Funding

Building a stronghold is expensive. You must have capital to get this enterprise underway.

You might draw funds from your coffers or find backers from among NPCs you meet.

Invest: If you invest 5,000 gp, you can skip this stage and move to stage 2. If you reach the conclusion with a success, you spend this money to fund the construction. If you reach the conclusion with a failure, you lose 2,000 gp due to costs incurred before the construction fell apart.

Seek Investors: Make a Bluff or Diplomacy check against a hard DC.

Success by 5 or more: A friendly NPC who owed you a favor gladly provides the financial backing and also recommends workers to help complete the project. You gain a +2 bonus to the Streetwise check during the next stage. Go to stage 2.

Success: You scrape together funds from numerous sources, though you likely incurred a few debts. Go to stage 2.

Failure: You receive some funding for the project, but you must front the rest. If you spend 1,000 gp, go to stage 2. Otherwise, go to the conclusion.

Failure by 5 or more: You can't find any funding at all. If you spend 2,500 gp, go to stage 2. Otherwise, go to the conclusion.

Stage 2: Recruit Workers

With funds in place, you scour the community for workers.

You need an architect, masons, carpenters, and laborers to complete this project. Make a Streetwise check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You find skilled workers to help you complete this project. Reduce the time it takes by 1d4 months. Additionally, you gain a +2 bonus to skill checks for the duration of this challenge. Go to stage 3.

Success: You find the necessary workers to build the stronghold. Go to stage 3.

Failure: You find poor workers. You can retry this check with a -5 penalty or take a -2 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge, in which case go to stage 3. In any event, add 1d4 months to the time of the challenge. If you get this result or worse a second time, go to the conclusion.

Failure by 5 or more: You find only the worst workers. You can retry this check with a -5 penalty or you take a -4 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge, in which case go to stage 3. In either case, add 1d8 months to the time. If you get this result a second time, go to the conclusion.

Stage 3: Choose the Site

You study the land or histories for a suitable site.

You need to choose a place to build your stronghold. Make a Dungeoneering, History, or Nature check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You find an excellent site with plenty of raw materials to speed up the construction. Reduce the time by 1d4 months. Additionally, during the next stage, you can roll twice for your skill check and use the higher result. Go to stage 4.

Success: You find a suitable site. Go to stage 4.

Failure: You find a poor site. Add 1d4 months to the time. Go to stage 4.

Failure by 5 or more: Your chosen site proves disastrous. Add 1d8 months to the time. During the next stage, you must roll twice for your skill check and use the lower result.

Stage 4: Manage the Workers

Work is underway. You must watch your workers closely to keep their morale high.

You keep a close eye on your workers to make sure they do a good job and to avoid working them too

hard. Make an Insight check against an easy DC or an Intimidate check against a moderate DC. If you are trained in Diplomacy, you gain a +2 bonus to this check.

Success: The workers are productive. Go to the conclusion.

Failure: The workers are unhappy and eventually quit. Go to the conclusion.

Conclusion

After months of construction, you either have a new stronghold or a partial one.

If you reached the conclusion from a success, you now have a stronghold and the needed staff to maintain it.

If you reached the conclusion from a failure in stage 1, 2, or 3, the stronghold is not raised.

If you reached the conclusion from a failure in stage 4, the stronghold is partly complete but uninhabitable. You can run through the challenge again to complete it.

Craft a Magic Item

You labor in a workshop to create a new magic item.

Magic items are the stuff of legend. These trinkets, baubles, weapons, and armor exceed the capabilities of mundane equipment and make the impossible possible. Common magic items can sometimes be found in shops and bazaars, but the more powerful and desirable items are far harder to find since the methods for creating them have passed from mortal knowledge. Those well versed in magical study and artifice can put their talents to use and create new common magic items to add to their arsenals.

Achievement (Material): Choose a magic item of your level or lower that the DM approves for this process. (The DM can require you to adventure to acquire some needed materials before even starting

the process.) If you succeed on the challenge, you create the chosen item.

Time: 1 day

Stage 1: Research the Formula

You pore through old manuscripts to find the procedure and ingredients required to create the item you desire.

Magic items are difficult to create. They require strange ingredients combined in precise ways spelled out in hard-to-find writings. To find the formula to create the magic item, you must research it. Make a History check against a hard DC.

Success by 5 or more: You discover a complete formula for creating the item, including substitute ingredients in case you can't find the preferred ones. You gain a +2 bonus to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 2.

Success: You find a workable formula to create the magic item. Go to stage 2.

Failure: You find an incomplete formula to create the magic item. You take a -2 penalty to the next skill check during this challenge. Go to stage 2.

Failure by 5 or more: You find a dubious formula. You take a -2 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 2.

Stage 2: Find the Materials

You scour apothecary shops and haggle with alchemists to find the materials you need.

To craft the item, you must have materials. These include the object to be enchanted, alchemical reagents to bind the magic, and other oddities as called for in the formula.

Use Residium: If you have residuum, you can substitute an amount up to the magic item's market price. If you use half residuum, you gain a +5 bonus to the Streetwise check during this stage. If you use all residuum, you don't have to make a check, and you

gain a +5 bonus to the next skill check during this challenge.

Gather Materials: You must pay for materials worth the magic item's market price. Make a Streetwise check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You find exceptional materials. You gain a +2 bonus to the skill check during stage 4. Go to stage 3.

Success: You find the materials you need. Go to stage 3.

Failure: You find poor materials. You take a -2 penalty to the skill check during stage 4. Go to stage 3.

Failure by 5 or more: You find materials, but they are neither complete nor the right ones. You take a -2 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 3.

Stage 3: Prepare the Ingredients

Preparing the ingredients exposes you to weird energies.

You prepare the ingredients. Make an Endurance check against an easy DC.

Success: You assemble and prepare the ingredients with no trouble. Go to stage 4.

Failure: The magic addles you. Take a -2 penalty to the next check during this challenge. Go to stage 4.

Failure by 5 or more: You lose consciousness. Choose one of the following: go back to stage 2 and make another Streetwise check; spend one-fifth of the magic item's market price to replace the ruined materials; or go to stage 4 but take a -5 penalty to your Arcana check.

Stage 4: Bind the Magic

You intone the mystical words to flood the item with magical power.

The final step is to bind magic to the item. Make an Arcana check against a moderate DC.

Success: You bind the magic. Go to the conclusion.

OTHER NARRATIVE CHALLENGES

The sample narrative challenges are in no way exhaustive or representative of all that's possible using these rules. You could use these rules to do any of the following.

- ◆ Assassinate a minor NPC (influence)
- ◆ Attract religious followers (association)
- ◆ Bargain with a fiend (information)
- ◆ Find a map (information)
- ◆ Find a ritual (material)
- ◆ Get a prisoner released (influence)
- ◆ Impersonate a character (information)
- ◆ Lift a curse (material)
- ◆ Raise an army (association)
- ◆ Raise the dead (material)
- ◆ Run a business (association)
- ◆ Secure passage on a ship (influence)
- ◆ Train an animal (material)
- ◆ Train an apprentice (association)
- ◆ Win a boon (influence)

When creating a narrative challenge, work with the DM to pick skills that relate to the challenge. Each challenge usually has one easy DC, two moderate DCs, and maybe one hard DC, depending on the challenge.

Failure: You bind the magic to the object, but something goes wrong. Go to the conclusion.

Conclusion

You complete the work to produce the magic item.

If you reached the conclusion from a success, you gain the magic item you created.

If you reached the conclusion from a failed check, you gain the magic item you created, but it doesn't work properly. After each extended rest, roll 1d6. On an odd number, the magic item doesn't function. On an even number, the magic item works normally. This penalty ends when you reach three milestones. Optionally, the DM can create a quirk or curse for the item, the severity of which should be based on how badly you failed.

Forge a Document

You make a convincing copy from an original.

Proper documentation can open doors otherwise closed to you. An invitation might mean the difference between a night at the duke's ball and a night in the cold. A medallion could grant you entry to a wizard academy, while orders with the king's seal could put a fast ship in your hands.

Achievement (Association): You work to create a forgery of a document, badge, or other unique item. If you succeed, you create a copy only the best-trained eye can detect.

Time: 3 days

Stage 1: Find an Original

You need an original to make a good copy.

Original in Hand: If you already have the object you hope to copy, skip this stage and proceed to stage 3.

Original Needed: You hunt for the original you hope to copy. Make a Streetwise check against a hard DC.

Success by 5 or more: You find a good and unguarded copy. You gain a +2 bonus to the Stealth check during the next stage. Go to stage 2.

Success: You find a copy. Go to stage 2.

Failure: You find a guarded copy. You take a -2 penalty to the Stealth check during the next stage. Go to stage 2.

Failure by 5 or more: You get a dubious copy. You can skip stage 2 and go to stage 3, but you take a -4 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Or you can retry this check at a -4 penalty. If you get this result a second time, go to the conclusion.

Stage 2: Steal the Original

Finding an original doesn't do you any good unless you can study it.

You steal or borrow the original without anyone noticing. Make a Stealth or Thievery check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You slip away with the original. No one notices it is missing. Go to stage 3.

Success: You slip away with the original. The owner learns it is missing after 2d10 + 2 days. If you don't use the copy before then, the forgery fails. Go to stage 3.

Failure: You slip away with the original. The owner learns it is missing after 1d6 + 2 days. If you don't use the copy before then, the forgery fails. Go to stage 3.

Failure by 5 or more: Circumstances thwarted your effort to acquire the original. You can retry the skill check at a -5 penalty. If you get this result a second time, go to the conclusion.

Stage 3: Prepare Materials

After examining the original, you construct a short list of materials you need to create a good forgery.

You gather and prepare your materials. Make an Arcana, History, or Nature check against a moderate DC. If you are trained in Streetwise, you gain a +2 bonus to this check.



Success by 5 or more: You find materials of the highest quality. You gain a +2 bonus to the Thievery check during the next stage. Go to stage 4.

Success: You find what you need. Go to stage 4.

Failure: You find most of what you need. You take a -2 penalty to the Thievery check during the next stage. Go to stage 4.

Failure by 5 or more: You find very little of what you need. You take a -5 penalty to the Thievery check during the next stage. Go to stage 4.

Stage 4: Create the Forgery

You labor over your creation to produce as close a copy as you can.

You create the forgery. Make a Thievery check against a moderate DC.

Success or Failure: You create the forgery. Go to the conclusion.

Conclusion

To identify the document as a forgery, another creature must make a Perception check against a DC equal to your Thievery check result from stage 4.

Infiltrate a Guarded Location

You slip into a guarded location to make off with an important clue.

There are places off limits even to adventurers. The prison beneath the duke's palace, a powerful merchant's vault, a wizard's secret laboratory—all these and more are places both guarded and secure. If what you seek lies within such a place, you must use all your skills to get in and out before anyone notices.

Achievement (Information): You infiltrate a guarded location to discover its secrets. With a success, you slip in, learn what you need, and slip out again without arousing suspicion.

Time: 1 day

Stage 1: Scope Out the Location

You stake out the location to find a way inside.

Knowing the location can make your job all the easier. You examine the site, watching for guard movements and searching out access points. Make a Perception check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You find a gap in the location's defenses. You gain a +2 bonus to the skill check during the next stage. Go to stage 2.

Success: You find a way in. Go to stage 2.

Failure: You find a way in, but it will be tough. You take a -2 penalty to the skill check during the next stage. Go to stage 2.

Failure by 5 or more: While you are looking for a way in, a guard notices you. Make a Bluff check against a moderate DC. If you succeed, go to stage 2. If you fail, go to the conclusion.

Stage 2: Get Inside

Having scoped out the location, it's time to break in.

You slip into the location. You might have to climb over a wall, wriggle through a tight place, or break down a door. Make an Acrobatics, Athletics, or Thievery check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You get inside without attracting any attention. You gain a +2 bonus to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 3.

Success: You get inside. Go to stage 3.

Failure: You make it inside, but you cause too much noise in doing so. You take a -2 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 3.

Failure by 5 or more: While trying to get inside, you encounter some guards. Make a Bluff or Stealth check against a hard DC. If you succeed, go to stage 3. If you fail, go to the conclusion.

Stage 3: Overcome Obstacle

While navigating the location, you encounter a tough obstacle.

A locked door, trap, or some other obstacle blocks your progress. Make an Athletics or Thievery check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You bypass the obstacle without making a sound. Go to stage 5.

Success: You overcome the obstacle. Proceed to stage 4.

Failure: You make too much noise getting through the obstacle. You take a -2 penalty to the skill check in stage 4. Go to stage 4.

Failure by 5 or more: You must find another way. Make a Dungeoneering or Perception check against a hard DC. If you succeed, go to stage 4. If you fail, go to the conclusion.

Stage 4: Evade Guards

A guard patrol comes your way!

You must hide, or else talk your way past the guards. Make a Bluff, Intimidate, or Stealth check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You maneuver past the guards without trouble. You gain a +2 bonus to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 5.

Success: You find a way around or through the guards. Go to stage 5.

Failure: The guards are suspicious. You take a -2 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 4.

Failure by 5 or more: The guards spot you or don't buy your story. Go to the conclusion.

Stage 5: Find Information

You search for the information you need.

You reach the location or the person with the information. Make a Bluff, Diplomacy, or Perception check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You gain the information so quickly the guards don't have time to react. Go to the conclusion.

Success: You get the information. Go to stage 6.

Failure: While you are taking the information, the guards arrive. Make a Bluff or Stealth check against a moderate DC. If you succeed, go to stage 6. If you fail, go to the conclusion.

Failure by 5 or more: The guards find you. Make a Bluff or Stealth check against a hard DC. If you succeed, go to stage 6. If you fail, go to the conclusion.

Stage 6: Escape Undetected

You slip away before anyone notices you were there. Or at least you hope to.

You retrace your steps to escape. Make a Dungeoneering check against a moderate DC.

Success: You escape. Go to the conclusion.

Failure: You get lost. Make a Perception check against a moderate DC. If you succeed, you escape. Go to the conclusion. If you fail, the guards drag you. Go to the conclusion.

Failure by 5 or more: You stumble into the guards who carry you. Go to the conclusion.

Conclusion

How well you navigated the location determines your success.

If you reached the conclusion from a success, you gained the information you sought.

If you reached this conclusion from a failure before getting the information, you don't get it, and you are tossed out.

If you reached the conclusion from a failure after getting the information, you are beaten, questioned, and beaten some more before you escape.

Hunt Wild Game

You creep through the wild, searching for your prey.

When foraging isn't enough to keep you and your allies fed, you can always turn to hunting game to put food in your bellies. Hunting requires patience, a keen eye, and a familiarity with the wilderness.

Achievement (Material): You stalk game in the wild. If you succeed, you gain food enough to feed you and up to five allies for 1d4 days.

Time: 6 hours

Stage 1: Choose a Site

Using your experience as a hunter, you choose a likely site to hunt your prey.

You recall information about where game might be found. Make a Nature check against an easy DC. Use Dungeoneering if you're in an underground location.

Success by 5 or more: You know an excellent site. You gain a +2 bonus to the Perception check during the next stage. Go to stage 2.

Success: You know a serviceable site. Go to stage 2.

Failure: You go to a site. There's not a lot of game. You take a -2 penalty to the Perception check during the next stage. Go to stage 2.

Failure by 5 or more: While headed to a good site, you come across a monster. Make an Intimidate or Stealth check against a moderate DC. If you succeed, go to stage 2. If you fail, you are attacked. Go to the conclusion.

Stage 2: Find Tracks

You search for tracks in the underbrush.



You scour the terrain for tracks to follow your prey. Make a Perception check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You find fresh tracks. You gain a +2 bonus to the Perception check during the next stage. Go to stage 3.

Success: You find tracks. Go to stage 3.

Failure: You find faint tracks. You take a -2 penalty to the Perception check during the next stage. Go to stage 3.

Failure by 5 or more: You find old and faint tracks. You take a -5 penalty to the Perception check during the next stage. Go to stage 3.

Stage 3: Stalk Your Prey

You follow the tracks to make the kill.

The tracks lead into the wild. Make a Perception check against a moderate DC. If you are trained in Nature, you gain a +2 bonus to this check.

Success by 5 or more: You come upon the beast while it's grazing. You gain a +2 bonus to the attack roll during the next stage. Go to stage 4.

Success: You find the beast. Go to stage 4.

Failure: You see the beast, but you startle it. You take a -2 penalty to the attack roll during the next stage. Go to stage 4.

Failure by 5 or more: You lose the trail. Go back to stage 2. If you get this result a second time, go to the conclusion.

Stage 4: Take the Shot

You fix the target in your sights and take the shot.

You make an attack to bring down the beast. Make a ranged basic attack against an AC equal to 14 + your level.

Hit by 5 or more: You fell the beast in a single shot. Go to the conclusion.

Hit: You hit the beast, but it runs off. Make a Perception check against an easy DC. If you succeed, you

find the carcass. If you fail, you don't find the carcass. Go to the conclusion.

Miss: You nick the beast. Make another attack roll at a -2 penalty. If you hit, you drop the beast. If you miss, the beast gets away. Go to the conclusion.

Miss by 5 or more: You miss completely and the beast runs off. Go to the conclusion.

Conclusion

Your hunting expedition is done—will you go hungry or not?

If you reached the conclusion from a hit, you provide food for yourself and up to five allies for 3 days.

If you reached the conclusion from a failure or a miss, you don't make a kill. You can try again the next day.

Join a Thieves' Guild

The thieves' guild is one of the most connected and powerful underworld agencies in the city.

A thieves' guild is a criminal organization made up of thieves, robbers, and cutpurses. The guild exists for its members' mutual protection and to ensure everyone involved gets a fair take. The guild master determines who gets robbed and who doesn't, manages the operations, and keeps order . . . of a sort.

Achievement (Association): Joining a thieves' guild gives you access to an influential underworld organization. You gain a +2 bonus to Streetwise checks in any community where the guild operates.

Time: 3 days

Stage 1: Make Contact

The thieves' guild doesn't let just anyone inside its circle. You must first make contact with a member.

You ask questions and snoop around to find a guild member. Make a Streetwise check against a moderate

DC. If you have training in Thievery, you gain a +2 bonus to this check.

Success by 5 or more: You've impressed someone in the guild and encounter someone friendly. You get a +2 bonus to the skill check during the next stage. Go to stage 2.

Success: You encounter a guild member. Go to stage 2.

Failure: Your questions attract attention from the wrong sorts. A guild member finds you but is unfriendly. You take a -2 penalty to the skill check during the next stage. Go to stage 2.

Failure by 5 or more: Your snooping leads you to an encounter with a hostile guild member. You take a -5 penalty to the skill check during the next stage. Go to stage 2.

Stage 2: Get an Audience

The guild agent is your portal to the guild master and membership.

You must convince the guild member to take you to the guild master. Make a Bluff, Diplomacy, or Intimidate check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: The guild member is impressed and vouches for you. You gain a +2 bonus to the skill check during the next stage. Go to stage 3.

Success: The guild member agrees to take you to the guild master. Go to stage 3.

Failure: The guild member will take you to the guild master only if you pay a bribe. The bribe must be 10 gp per level in the heroic tier, 100 gp per level in the paragon tier, or 1,000 gp per level in the epic tier. If you pay the bribe, go to stage 3. If you don't, go to the conclusion.

Failure by 5 or more: The guild member refuses you. Go to the conclusion.

Stage 3: Impress the Guild Master

You stand before the shadowy master and ask to join the guild.

The guild master interviews you. How you acquit yourself determines whether you will be allowed to join. Make a Bluff or Diplomacy check against a hard DC.

Success by 5 or more: The guild master accepts you into the organization. Go to the conclusion.

Success: The guild master will accept you if you pass a test. Go to stage 4.

Failure: The guild master will accept you if you pass a tough test. You take a -2 penalty to the Thievery check during the next stage. Go to stage 4.

Failure by 5 or more: The guild master will accept you if you pass an impossible test. You take a -5 penalty to the Thievery check during the next stage. Go to stage 4.

Stage 4: Prove Your Stuff

You burgle a merchant's house, pick a constable's pocket, or snatch a jewel from the noble, all to prove your worth.

You must perform a crime to prove yourself. Make a Thievery check against a moderate DC. If you're trained in Bluff, you gain a +2 bonus to the check. If you're trained in Stealth, you gain a +2 bonus to the check.

Success: You impress the guild master. Go to the conclusion.

Failure: Your effort fails. Go to the conclusion.

Failure by 5 or more: Not only do you fail, but you are arrested.

Conclusion

Membership in the guild is yours, provided you impressed the master.

If you reached the conclusion from a success, you are a full member of the thieves' guild.

If you reached the conclusion from a failure, you are denied entry into the guild. You can try again when you gain a level.

Research in a Library

You scour a library for the information you seek.

In this dark age, books are rare. They are expensive to produce, hard to find, and costly to maintain. For these reasons, libraries are few and secure. Most libraries are cluttered with scrolls and manuscripts, disorganized and hard to navigate. Using a library to find information related to your subject is a challenge in itself.

Achievement (Information): You convince the librarian to grant you access to his or her repository, and you then scour the stacks to find relevant information. If you succeed, you gain a clue related to the problem you hope to overcome.

Time: 8 hours

Stage 1: Access the Library

Not just anyone can access a library.

You must convince the librarian to let you explore the library. Make a Bluff, Diplomacy, or Intimidate check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: The librarian lets you in and offers to help. You gain a +2 bonus to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 2.

Success: The librarian grants you access to the library. Go to stage 2.

Failure: The librarian denies you access to the library. You can sneak in by making a Stealth check against an easy DC. If you succeed, go to stage 2. If you fail, go to the conclusion.

Failure by 5 or more: The librarian refuses you entry and is suspicious. You can sneak in by making a Stealth check against a moderate DC. If you succeed, go to stage 2. If you fail, go to the conclusion.

Stage 2: Search the Library

You hunt through the mess to find the books you need.

The library's disorder makes it hard to find anything you need. Make a Perception check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You find materials valuable to your research. You gain a +2 bonus to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 3.

Success: You find useful materials. Go to stage 3.

Failure: You find materials that might be useful. You take a -2 penalty to the skill check during the next stage. Go to stage 3.

Failure by 5 or more: The information you find is dubious at best. You take a -5 penalty to the skill check during the next stage. Go to stage 3.

Stage 3: Study the Texts

You cross-reference the texts to find the clues you seek.

You examine the texts. Make a knowledge check related to the subject you are researching against a moderate DC.

Success: You find a clue. Go to the conclusion.

Failure: You find little of use. Go to the conclusion.

Conclusion

After spending hours in the library, you might have uncovered the information you need.

If you reached the conclusion from a success, you gain information about the subject matter you chose to research.

If you reached the conclusion from a failure, you learn nothing useful.

Track a Character

You know your quarry hides somewhere in the city.

Sometimes surreptitious investigation is more useful than a direct approach. You might suspect a character of some malfeasance, or maybe you think the character knows something or someone important, so you track down the character to learn what you can.

Achievement (Information): A success gives you information about where the character is hiding or what he or she is up to.

Time: 6 hours

Stage 1: Gather Intelligence

You hit the streets, looking for signs of your quarry.

You scour the city for the character you seek. Make a Streetwise check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You find a reliable witness who reveals where the target was last seen. You gain a +2 bonus to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 2.

Success: You find a witness who points you in the right direction. Go to stage 2.

Failure: You find an unreliable witness who gives you shaky information. You take a -2 penalty to the next skill check during this challenge. Go to stage 2.

Failure by 5 or more: The witness tells you where to go but tips off your quarry. You take a -2 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 2.

Stage 2: Stake Out

You come upon the place where the character was last seen.

Watching the location for your quarry will let you pick up the trail. To avoid notice, you need to find a hiding place. Make a Stealth check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You find an excellent hiding place with a clear view of the location. You gain a +2

bonus to the Perception check during the next stage. Go to stage 3.

Success: You find a suitable hiding place. Go to stage 3.

Failure: Your hiding place obstructs your view. You take a -2 penalty to the Perception check during the next stage. Go to stage 3.

Failure by 5 or more: Thugs compromise your hiding place. Make a Bluff or Intimidate check against a hard DC. If you succeed, you take a -2 penalty to the Perception check during the next stage and then go to stage 3. If you fail, the confrontation becomes a scuffle and your quarry slips away. Go to the conclusion.

Stage 3: Listen and Look

You watch the location, looking for any sign of the character.

From your hiding place, you watch for the character. Make a Perception check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You hear something or see movement from inside, letting you anticipate the character's exit. You gain a +2 bonus to Stealth checks during the next stage. Go to stage 4.

Success: You see the character emerge. Go to stage 4.

Failure: You are momentarily distracted and the character slips away. Make another Perception check against a moderate DC. On a success, you go to stage 4, but you take a -2 penalty on the Stealth check.

Failure by 5 or more: The character slips away from you. Go to the conclusion.

Stage 4: Follow

You shadow the character to see where he or she goes.

To shadow the character, you must stay out of sight. Make a Stealth check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: You follow closely enough to see and hear the character. You gain a +2 bonus to the next check during the challenge. Go to stage 5.

Success: You follow the character unseen. Go to stage 5.

Failure: You follow the character but are spotted. The character runs off. If you want to follow, make an Athletics check against a moderate DC. If you succeed, go to stage 5. If you fail or if you don't follow, go to the conclusion.

Failure by 5 or more: The character loses you. Go to the conclusion.

Stage 5: Learn

You catch the character in the act of doing something revealing.

You watch the character to see what he or she is up to. Make an Insight or Perception check against a moderate DC.

Success: You see or hear something important. Go to the conclusion.

Failure: You don't see anything conclusive. Go to the conclusion.

Conclusion

The information you sought is yours depending on how you handled the challenge.

If you reached the conclusion from a success, you learn something that exculpates or damns the character.

If you reached the conclusion from a failure, you might get a hint there's something going on, but you know nothing for certain.

Woo a Character

Whether for romance or for personal gain, you invest time and energy into making a friend.

A connection made today can prove useful to you at some point tomorrow. You might make an honest attempt to befriend another character, or you might seek a romantic involvement. Then again, you could

have other motives and look to exploit a character for what he or she can give you.

Achievement (Association): A successful venture wins admiration, respect, adoration, or friendship from another character.

Time: 2 weeks

Stage 1: Get an Introduction

It's often helpful to arrange an introduction when meeting someone new.

We've Met: If you have met the character before, you can skip this stage and proceed to stage 2.

Introductions Required: To aid in your wooing, you ask someone to set up an introduction and vouch for you. Make a Bluff, Diplomacy, or Intimidate check against a moderate DC.

Success by 5 or more: The character is enthusiastic and agrees. You gain a +2 bonus to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 2.

Success: The character agrees to introduce you. Go to stage 2.

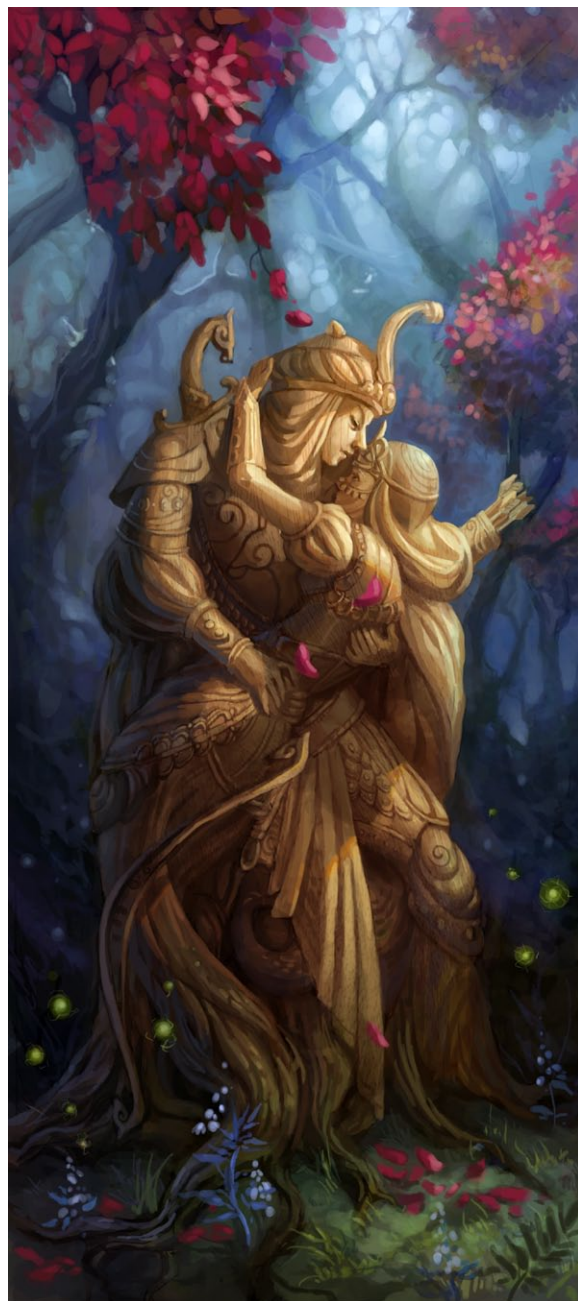
Failure: The character is reluctant to introduce you. Make a second check using a different skill from the one you used to gain this result. If you get this result a second time, the character refuses to introduce you and you take a -2 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge.

Failure by 5 or more: The character refuses to introduce you and in fact poisons the object of your attention against you. You take a -5 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 2 or the conclusion.

Stage 2: Learn about the Character

You ask around to learn more about the character.

You ask around or observe the character to get a sense of how to proceed. Make an Insight or Streetwise check against a moderate DC.



Success by 5 or more: You find out something very helpful. You gain a +2 bonus to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 3.

Success: You learn something of the character's interests. Go to stage 3.

Failure: You learn false information about the character and take a -2 penalty to the skill check during stage 4. Go to stage 3.

Failure by 5 or more: Your inquiries betray your intent. You take a -2 penalty to all skill checks for the duration of the challenge. Go to stage 3.

Stage 3: Make an Impression

A later meeting gives you a chance to win over the character.

You try to make a good impression. Choose one skill. Make a check using that skill against a hard DC. The DM might suggest a skill based on the character's personality.

Success by 5 or more: You amaze the character. You gain a +2 bonus to your next skill check during this challenge. Go to stage 5.

Success: You make an impression. Go to stage 5.

Failure: Your failed effort is a stumble. You take a -2 penalty to your next skill check during this challenge. Go to stage 5.

Failure by 5 or more: The character misunderstands you in a bad way. Go to the conclusion.

Stage 5: Friendship or Romance

You have one last chance to build this relation.

You make the move to become better acquainted. Make a Bluff or Diplomacy check against a moderate DC.

Success: A relationship is born. Go to the conclusion.

Failure: It's just not going to work. Go to the conclusion.

Conclusion

What is your future with this character?

If you reached the conclusion from a success, the character is helpful and regards you as a trusted friend or more.

If you reached the conclusion from a failure, the character is indifferent or unfriendly depending on how the challenge played out.

About the Author

Robert J. Schwalb has contributed design to or developed nearly two hundred roleplaying game titles for DUNGEONS & DRAGONS®, Warhammer Fantasy Roleplay, A Song of Ice and Fire RPG, Star Wars RPG, and the d20 system. Some of his more recent work for Wizards of the Coast can be found in *Book of Vile Darkness™* and *Player's Option: Heroes of the Elemental Chaos™*. He's also a regular contributor to both *Dragon* and *Dungeon* magazines. For more information about the author, be sure to check out his website at www.robertjschwalb.com or follow him on Twitter (@rjschwalb).